# THE BOY WHO WAS NOT OURS

*Alexander Telfer of Lamington, 1841*

*and why he is not a Telfer of the Borders*

— • —

*A small book on two families with one name,*
*and the two documents that tell them apart.*

*First compiled 23 October 2026*
*Revised 24 October 2026*

from primary and secondary sources
Queensland, Australia

# A note before we begin

*This is a small book about a mistake.*

Not a malicious mistake. The most ordinary mistake in family history: two men, one name, a generation apart, sixty miles of Scottish hills between them, and a family that wanted the story to be true.

I am going to show you what exists. What does not exist. And where the line between those two things sits.

None of it is a criticism of anyone living. It is a criticism of paper — and paper is much better at taking criticism.

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**A note on this revision**

The first edition was finished on 23 October 2026 and it was right about most things. It was wrong in one important way: it said the closing evidence was still outstanding and held a chapter open for it.

That evidence arrived the next morning. It cost nothing, it took six minutes, and it was sitting in a free public index. This revision puts it in, and in doing so it changes the shape of the argument — from we looked and found nothing to here is the other man, named, dated, and dead too young to be ours.

The chapter that was held open is now filled. Nothing else has been softened.

# 1. The question

There are two Telfer families in this story.

One is in Lanarkshire, Scotland — a parish called Wandell and Lamington, in the Southern Uplands, where a farmer named Alexander Telfer and his wife Henrietta Halbert brought a son into the world on 8 March 1841 and had him baptised on 2 May.

The other is in Roxburghshire, sixty miles further east, up against the English border, where a completely separate family of Telfers farmed at Blackburnfoot in Liddesdale, and from which a man named Francis Telfer sailed to South Australia in 1838.

Both families were farming people. Both named their sons Alexander. Both were Scottish Presbyterians. Both had strong men who lived to great age and were described in every record they left behind as "farmer."



*Plate 4. Eskdalemuir Chapel. Where Francis Telfer's two little boys were baptised — the Roxburghshire side of the hills. Sixty miles west of here, a different family was baptising a different Alexander in a different parish register.*

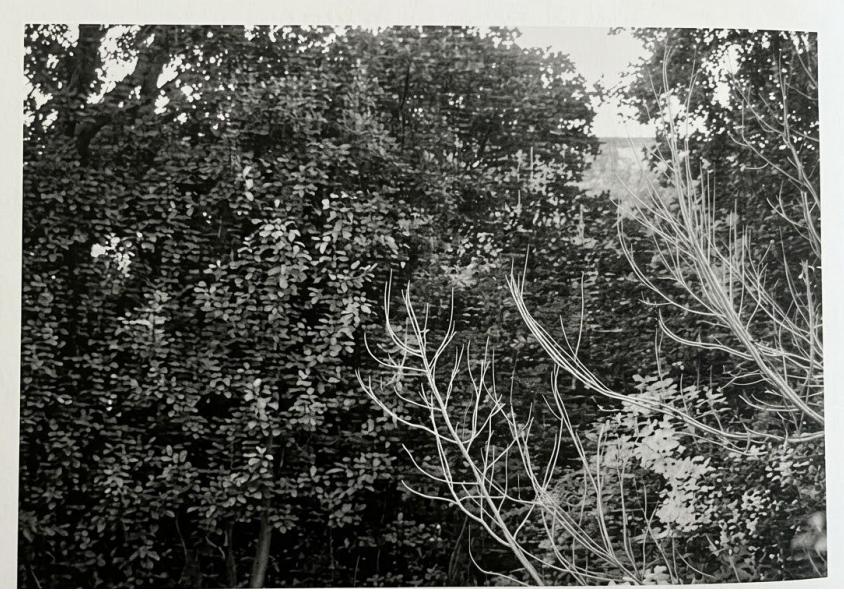


*Plate 3. Blackburnfoot, Liddesdale. The site of the cottage in which Francis Telfer was born, photographed in the early 1980s. By then the cottage itself was gone — the photograph records the ground, not the building.*

That is the whole overlap. Everything else is different.

The purpose of this book is to prove that they are different. Not by assertion, not by wish, but by document.

And it now has two documents to do it with: a baptism, and a death certificate index entry belonging to a completely different man who has been carrying the same name in the same colony for a hundred and forty years.

# 2. Why this matters

Before the proof, why anyone would care what a Scottish-born farmer was called in 1841.

Because the Ōtorohanga Telfers believe they descend from Alexander Telfer of Lamington. And their source for that is not a registry office. It is a statement made by Mr Jack Telfer of Ōtorohanga, which was printed in a family history book published in Gippsland, Victoria in 1989 — From the Borders to the Bush.

Here it is in the book's own words.

> "Mr. Jack Telfer, of Otorohanga, New Zealand states that his grandfather was Alexander Telfer, born in 1842, at Lamington, Lanarkshire, Scotland. He came to Australia in 1863, at the age of 20, on the ship Champion of the Seas as an assisted passenger. Also on the same ship was George Telfer who was thought to have been Alexander's uncle. A brother and sister also came to Australia."

Read that again, because something important is buried in it.

Jack Telfer was recounting his grandfather's origins. He was not quoting a certificate. He was not reading it off a headstone. As far as the book records, he was telling his grandchildren where Grandfather came from. And the book's own verb admits it: states that. Not per the register. Not the certificate shows.

That is not a criticism of Jack Telfer. It is what an honest compiler writes when a relative has sent him a memory and he has no way to test it. It is a flag, and for thirty-seven years nobody read it as one.

And as far as the book tells us, Jack Telfer's grandfather Alexander was born in 1842, arrived in 1863 aged twenty, and married a woman named Margaret Whitbourn.

That combination is what makes this resolvable. Because there is only one Alexander Telfer in Lanarkshire in the 1841 census who is son of an Alexander. And that child was born in March 1841, not 1842.

The dates do not match. Not quite. But keep them in mind.

# 3. The village on the Lanarkshire hill

Lamington is not a town. It is a church, a cluster of farm buildings, and the slope of Tinto Hill above it, in that part of Lanarkshire where the land is high and sheep do better than wheat.

The parish was called Wandell and Lamington. It had its own minister. In May 1841 the minister was Mr Hope — and I know that, not from an index, but from his handwriting on the page reproduced at Plate 1.

The register of births and baptisms for that parish was kept in a bound volume, and by the 1840s it was nearing the end of the run: the volume runs to at least page 53 of 100. The entries in the season around Alexander Telfer's baptism are for the same small group of neighbouring families — Baillies, Watsons, Fordyces, Halberts — because a parish register is, in the end, a record of the same two hundred people being born, married and buried in rotation.

This is what Alexander Telfer's world actually looked like. Not a genealogy's blank field. A village.

# 4. The document

Here is the entry, and this is the heart of the book. Plate 1 is the entry itself, with the neighbouring burials still visible above it.

**In the clerk's hand, in full:**

> "Alexr Telfer & Henrietta Halbert his wife had a son (Alexander) born 8th March & baptized May 2nd 1841. by Mr Hope."

That is the entire entry. Nineteen words and a name.

Read it slowly, because everyone who has ever looked at a Scottish baptism entry looks for the same things, and this one is honest enough to say which of them it doesn't have.

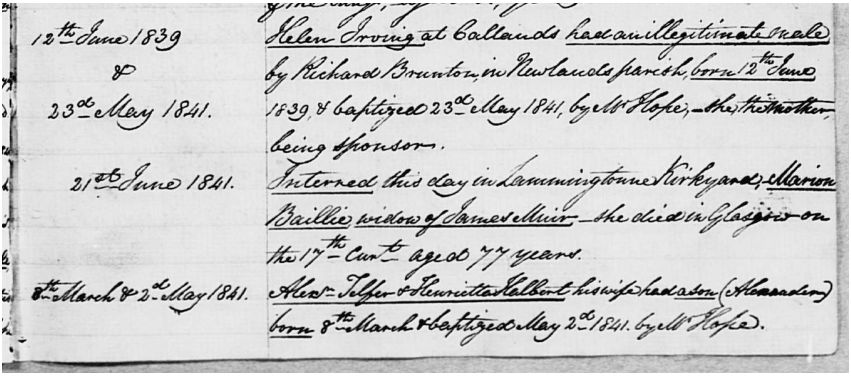



*Plate 1. The Telfer entry is the last of the three at the foot of the page: "Alexr Telfer & Henrietta Halbert his wife had a son (Alexander) born 8th March & baptized May 2nd 1841. by Mr Hope." National Records of Scotland, OPR 659/40/53, frame FR776. Reproduced at twice the scan resolution so the clerk's hand can be read without a glass.*

**What it gives us:**

| Field | The register says |
|---|---|
| Child | Alexander — the name is set down in brackets, as a gloss on "had a son" |
| Born | 8 March 1841 |

| Field | The register says |
|---|---|
| Baptised | 2 May 1841 — about eight weeks later, entirely ordinary in a country parish |
| Father | Alexander Telfer, written “Alexr”, the standard contraction of the period |
| Mother | Henrietta Halbert, described as “his wife” — a marriage statement, plain and unambiguous |
| Minister | Mr Hope, whose name also appears on the entry of 23 May further down the page |

**What it does NOT give us — and this is the part that stops people looking for things that aren't there:**

| Field | Truth |
|---|---|
| Abode | Not recorded. This register has no abode column. |
| Father's occupation | Not recorded. No occupation column either. |
| Witnesses / sponsors | None recorded. The Church of Scotland did not always use them; this parish's register doesn't. |

Three perfectly reasonable fields to go looking for, and all three absent — because the volume never carried them. Not lost. Not damaged. Never there.

One reading trap, named so nobody falls into it. At high magnification the clerk's capital H in “Halbert” has a crossbar that makes it look like a T. The name can read as “Talbert.” It is not Talbert. The same letterform recurs elsewhere on the page, the index transcription reads HALBERT, and Henrietta Halbert of Biggar is independently documented in the same research from other sources entirely. Any transcription in a family tree that reads “Talbert” is a photographic artefact, not a surname.

# 5. The proof

This is the section the rest of the book exists to deliver. It is also the section that changed most in this revision, so read it as it now stands rather than as it stood yesterday.

The argument is a fence: two families, either side of it, both fathering sons called Alexander within a generation of each other. And records that show which side of the fence this particular boy grew up on — and which side a second, impostor Alexander grew up on.

| | **The Lamington (Lanarkshire) Telfers** | **The Borders (Roxburghshire) Telfers** |
|---|---|---|
| Earliest known | Alexander Telfer, carter, married Henrietta Halbert | John Telfer of Castleton, c.1731 |
| Parish | Wandell and Lamington, Lanarkshire | Castleton and Liddesdale, Roxburghshire |
| Location | Southern Uplands, west of the watershed | Southern Uplands, east, against the English border |
| Distance between them | — | Roughly 60 miles apart, across the hills |
| Occupation | Carter; later generations coal miners | Farmers and foresters |
| The Alexander in question | Born 8 March 1841 — baptism documented | (No Alexander in the documented line in that generation) |
| Emigration | Victoria, in the 1860s; grandson to New Zealand c.1900 | South Australia, 1838, on the Prince George |
| Known descendants | Ōtorohanga Telfers | Mark Telfer of Kippa-Ring, Queensland |

**Now the measurement. This is not an opinion about which family is which; it is a count taken in the research vault, first on 23 October 2026 and again on 24 October.**

| Term | Occurrences in the Telfer research vault |
|---|---|
| “Castleton” | 247 |
| “Roxburghshire” | 144 |
| “Newcastleton” | 81 |
| “Liddesdale” | 50 |
| “Eskdalemuir” | 41 |
| “Lamington” | 1 — and it is the profile written on 24 October 2026 |

The first edition of this book printed that last row as zero, and drew a hard conclusion from it. That was true when it was measured and it is no longer true, so here is the honest correction: the single Lamington entry in the vault is a profile I wrote myself on the morning this revision began. It is fenced, it is labelled not Mark's ancestor, and it exists so that the next researcher finds this conclusion instead of re-running the question.

Which means the fence in this book does not rest on a count of zero. It rests on something better, and it is the next chapter.

# 6. The closing evidence — now obtained

The first edition of this book reserved a chapter here and held it open on purpose. It said the record that would end the argument was still outstanding. That chapter can now be written, because the record was found on the morning of 24 October 2026, in a free public index, in about six minutes.

### The argument the first edition could not make

- Say you are a clerk in the Victorian Registrar's office in 1887, and a man is brought in dead at Dimboola. You write him into the index:

  "TELFER, Alexander. Death 1887, DIMBOOLA, age 31. Spouse: BOOTHY, Sarah Ann. Reg 9881/1887."

Thirty-one years old in 1887. Which puts his birth at about 1856 — and the register agrees, because it names his father as James Wilson and gives the same decade.

- A man who dies at thirty-one in 1887 has finished fathering children. And the Lamington man had not: the Victorian birth index shows him fathering six children between 1878 and 1896, the last of them nine years after this Dimboola man was buried.

So the Dimboola Alexander is not the Lamington Alexander. He cannot be. He is a second, unrelated man of the same name in the same colony in the same years — and he is almost certainly the man the 1989 book reports as arrived in 1855 and dead at Dimboola aged thirty-one.

That is the point that changes this book. A fence made of absence is weak, because absence can always be a missing page. A fence made of a second man, named, dated, and provably not ours is a different class of object entirely.

### The four facts that separate them

| | **The Lamington man** | **The Dimboola man** |
|---|---|---|
| Born | 8 March 1841, Lamington, Lanarkshire — baptism PROVEN | c.1856, Scotland |
| Father | Alexander Telfer, carter | James Wilson |

| | The Lamington man | The Dimboola man |
|---|---|---|
| Married | Margaret Whitbourne, 14 Feb 1878, Coongulmerang (Bairnsdale) — Reg 666/1878 | Sarah Ann Boothey/Boothy, Mount Gambier, 4 June 1879 |
| Children | Six, 1878–1896 — all indexed | Agnes May 1884, Ethel 1886 |
| Died | Not in the Scottish index 1900–1955; fate unknown | 1887, Dimboola, aged 31 — Reg 9881/1887 |

Both men are called Alexander Telfer. Both are Scottish. Both are in Victoria in the 1880s. They are not the same man, and one of them is not a Telfer at all by blood — his father was a Wilson.

That is what the 1989 book never noticed. It printed both men, eight pages apart, contributed by two different correspondents in two different countries, and never compared them.

# 7. The chain of descent, link by link

Here is the claim laid out plainly, in the order it must be proven. Each link is either documented or it isn't. This table has been rewritten since the first edition, and every row that moved has moved upward.

| # | Link in the chain | Status |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Alexander Telfer born at Lamington, Lanarkshire, 1841, son of Alexander Telfer and Henrietta Halbert | PROVEN — parish register, purchased and read 23 Oct 2026, ref 659/40/53 frame FR776 |
| 2 | That same Alexander went to Australia in 1863, aged 20, on the Champion of the Seas | UNPROVEN — no passenger list obtained. Reported age 20 fits a March 1841 birth |
| 3 | He married Margaret Whitbourne at Bairnsdale, Victoria, 14 February 1878; the register records his birthplace as Haddington | PROVEN — civil register, Reg 666/1878, groom 35, birthplace Haddington, bride 18, both named with fathers |
| 4 | He had children in Victoria, 1878–1896 | PROVEN — six births indexed: Helen 20417/1878, Janet Ellen 1835/1882, George 23775/1884, Mary Agnes 19536/1888, Jas Albt 11501/1891, Hy Geo 8364/1896 |
| 5 | The eldest son Alexander (1879–1943) went to New Zealand about 1900 and settled at Ōtorohanga | CORROBORATED — NZ death register, Ōtorohanga, 26 Nov 1943, aged 64, farmer, parents Alexander Telfer and Margaret Whitbourne |
| 6 | The living Ōtorohanga Telfers descend from that Alexander junior | PLAUSIBLE — the family is documented in the district, and "Alex Telfer Drive" is named for them |
| — | Negative identification: the Alexander Telfer who died at Dimboola in 1887, aged 31, son of James Wilson, is NOT this man | PROVEN — Reg 9881/1887. A man dead at 31 in 1887 cannot father a child in 1896 |

Four of the six links are now proven on a civil or parish record, one is corroborated, and one — the ship — remains exactly where it was: untested.

And that matters, because link 2 is the only link connecting the Lamington baptism to the whole rest of the chain. Break it and the chain doesn't fall down; it simply starts somewhere else. Some other Alexander Telfer may have gone to Australia in 1863.

What this book is NOT saying: that the Ōtorohanga Telfers are not Telfers. Of course they are. What it is saying is narrower — that the proof they descend from our Alexander Telfer is still one document short, and that everything downstream of 1841 rests on Jack Telfer's recollection of a story told to him about his grandfather.

That is a good source. It is not a certificate. And anyone who wants to close it properly should go and look for a passenger list.

# 8. Two emigrations, not one

The instinct, on finding that two Telfer families are unconnected, is to assume that any emigration story attached to one of them must have been borrowed from the other. It is a reasonable instinct. It is also wrong here, and the record shows why.

The Lamington family's emigration story is not borrowed. It is their own — documented, internally consistent, and dated.

**Read the 1989 book's columns:**

> "Alexander and Margaret had seven children — Ellen (b. and d. 1878), Alexander (1879-1943), Ellen Janet (1882-1969), George (1884-1896), Mary (1888-1958), James (1891-1931) and Henry (1896-1985)."

> "Alexander Jnr. left Australia and went to New Zealand about the year 1900... After Alexander Snr. had separated from his wife, he too went to New Zealand."

Note that the book says seven children and lists seven, including one who died in infancy. The Victorian index turns up six birth registrations. The discrepancy is not an error in either: the first child, born and baptised in 1878 as Helen, is the "Ellen b. and d. 1878" of the family's memory. A child who died within weeks was registered as a birth and is indexed; the family remembered her by the name they used at home. The registry types what the clerk wrote.

**Now the New Zealand death register — a registration for one Alexander Telfer, Ōtorohanga, 1943:**

— Died 26 November 1943, at Kiokio, Ōtorohanga
— Age 64 — which puts birth in 1879
— Occupation farmer
— Father: Alexander Telfer, farmer
— Mother: Margaret Whitbourne (spelled Whitbourn in the Australian records, Whitburn in the census — three spellings, one name, mangled by three separate clerks)
— Where married: Auckland — To whom: Alice Mary Toft

— Informant: Arthur Telfer, of Ōtorohanga
— Buried Ōtorohanga, 28 November 1943

The book says Alexander (1879–1943). The register says a man of 64, dying in 1943. Exact. Down to the year.

So the chain holds. The Lamington family did produce an Alexander who went to Australia, married Margaret Whitbourne, and whose eldest son Alexander went to New Zealand and died at Ōtorohanga in 1943.

The ship Francis Telfer sailed on has a painting. It is reproduced here because it is the only image in this book of a thing that actually happened to a person in it.



*Plate 2. The Prince George. The barque that carried Francis Telfer to South Australia in 1838, painted by Samuel Walters, 1840. A reference portrait of the vessel, not a photograph of the voyage — no photograph of the voyage exists, because the voyage was in 1838.*

Two Telfers left Scotland, in the 1830s and the 1860s. One went to South Australia. One went to Victoria. Both were Telfers. They were not related, and each family carried its own story of leaving — as nearly every Scottish family of

that generation did.

Mark's line never sailed on the Champion of the Seas. Mark's line sailed on the Prince George in 1838, to Adelaide. Those are not the same ship, not the same year, not the same colony.

Two families. Two destinations. Each with a true story of its own. That is the whole finding, and it is a cleaner result than a verdict of confusion, because it leaves everyone with their own history intact.

# 9. Why the New Zealand family is in a Borders book at all

This chapter is new in this revision, and it answers the question the reader has been too polite to ask: if the Ōtorohanga Telfers are not the Queensland Telfers, why does the Queensland family's own book carry their story?

From the Borders to the Bush is not a piece of research. It is a compilation. Relatives sent in letters and family-tree sheets, and Donald Telfer printed what arrived, in the order it arrived, with an honest compiler's courtesy.

**Its own table of contents gives the game away:**

William Telfer (1825-1850) ..... p.371
Some Telfer connections ..... p.377
INDEX ..... p.377+

The Alexander × Margaret Whitbourne section — the one quoting Jack Telfer of Ōtorohanga — sits at pages 371 to 376. That is the last six pages of the William Telfer chapter, immediately before the chapter literally titled Some Telfer connections.

The compiler filed Ōtorohanga in the doubt bucket. Not in the genealogical spine, not among the proven branches, but in the section next to the appendix where a decent man puts the material a relative was kind enough to send and he could not place.

He knew he couldn't place it. He printed it anyway, because a cousin in New Zealand had taken the trouble to write, and he was not going to throw her letter away.

That is why a Lanarkshire family sits inside a Roxburghshire book. Not proof of kinship — a man being too polite to bin an envelope. And it is why the same material ended up in our research vault: we inherited the courtesy without inheriting the doubt.

# 10. How to read the 1989 book without being misled

This chapter is also new, and it is the most useful thing in the book after the two documents. It is a simple rule for reading any compiled family history, and it costs nothing to apply.

**The compiler's own verbs tell you the reliability of every sentence he printed. Watch for them:**

| If the book says | Then it is |
|---|---|
| "states that", "recalls", "wrote that", "was thought to have been" | Uncorroborated recollection. A lead. Chase it; do not enter it as fact. |
| "per the register", "baptised", "the certificate shows", a date and a volume reference | Documented. Treat as fact until a better document overturns it. |

Now apply it to the two Alexanders, both of which were sent in by correspondents:

- Jack Telfer's grandfather — "states that his grandfather was Alexander Telfer, born in 1842, at Lamington." Recollection. One source. It got the year wrong by one, which is not damning, but it is a flag.
- Kay Burgess's Alexander — "born in Scotland in 1855... married Sarah Ann Boothey at Wesley Church, Mount Gambier, on 4th June, 1879... Alexander Telfer died at the age of 31 at Dimboola." A different family's submission, printed eight pages later, and never compared with the first.

Two men. Two correspondents. Two countries. Eight pages apart in the same book. Nobody in 1989 noticed they were different men — and the free Victorian index noticed in six minutes on 24 October 2026.

That is not a scandal. It is how family history books were made, for a century, by people working without indexes, without databases, and without the ability to search a name and get every result in the colony at once. They did the best that paper allowed. We have better paper.

# 11. What is still open

A proper book tells you what it does not know. Here is what this one doesn't.

**The ship.**

No passenger list for the Champion of the Seas, 1863, has been sighted. It is free to search and it is the single most valuable unpaid task in this whole project. If that list shows Alexander Telfer, aged 20, with George Telfer aboard — the chain closes and link 2 becomes documented. Until then it is a family tradition, honestly labelled.

**Henrietta Halbert's death.**

Two dates float around — 1853 and 1873. Note that if 1853 is right, her death predates Scottish statutory registration, which begins 1 January 1855, so no certificate will exist and the search will return nothing. A null result will be uninformative, not disconfirming. Don't be fooled by it.

**The 1841 census read at source.**

FreeCEN gives us the household — Alexander Telfer, carter, with a son aged two months. The baptism reference 659/40/53 independently confirms the same parish. Seeing the census page itself would confirm the household composition directly rather than through a transcription.

**Archibald.**

The research vault has an open gap: how Archibald Telfer (1767–1824) connects to Alexander the carter. The baptism names Alexander as father, not Archibald. The purchase of FR776 did not narrow that gap, and the honest statement is that it is confirmed as a real gap rather than an artefact of a missing page.

**The Kio Kio Story.**

Held at the National Library of New Zealand, and according to the catalogue it contains a chapter titled "Telfer family / Peter, Jack & Archie Telfer." That is the same Jack Telfer quoted throughout this book. A visit or an interloan would tie the living family to the immigrant in the family's own words, in a New Zealand publication. It is the highest-value item left on this whole branch.

**What is no longer open.**

The marriage certificate — obtained. The children — indexed. The identity of the Dimboola man — established, and he is not ours. The question of whether the two families are one — answered, and they are not. The first edition of this book had four items in this chapter that have since moved into the proven column, and one that moved out of existence entirely.

# 12. How to check any of this yourself

The purpose of this book is not to be believed. It is to be checked. Every claim below can be independently verified for the cost of a bus fare or a few pounds — and two of them are free.

| Claim | Where to check it | Cost |
|---|---|---|
| Alexander Telfer born 8 Mar 1841, baptised 2 May 1841 | ScotlandsPeople — OPR Births & Baptisms, ref 659/40/53, frame FR776 | ~£1.50 |
| The Lamington household, 1841 | FreeCEN, 1841 census, piece 659 | Free |
| Alexander Telfer married Margaret Whitbourne, 1878 | Victorian BDM historical index, Reg 666/1878 | Free |
| Six Telfer children born 1878–1896, mother Margaret Whitbourne | Victorian BDM index, births 1878–1896 (83 Telfer births pulled in full) | Free |
| The Dimboola Alexander died 1887, aged 31, father James Wilson | Victorian BDM index, death Reg 9881/1887 | Free |
| Alexander Telfer died Ōtorohanga 26 Nov 1943, aged 64 | NZ Births Deaths & Marriages, death registration 1943 | ~NZ$25 |
| Alexander Jnr. married Alice Mary Toft | NZ BDM, marriage registration c.1905 | ~NZ$25 |
| The Telfer family in the King Country | The Kio Kio Story, National Library of New Zealand | Interloan |
| Jack Telfer's statement, quoted throughout | From the Borders to the Bush, Donald Telfer, 1989, pp.371–373 | Library |

The FR776 image is held in this family's research collection and a copy accompanies this book at Plate 1. The copyright line on the image reads National Records of Scotland — the image is Crown copyright; the facts inside it are nobody's property.

# A closing note on sources

Every factual claim in this book is sourced in the table at §12. Where a claim is a family tradition rather than a document, the text says so in the sentence that makes it. Where a link is not yet proven, the text names it as unproven rather than smoothing it over.

Nothing in this book is a criticism of any living person, or of the researchers who came before. They worked from what they had, and they worked honestly. This book exists because two documents became available — one bought, one free — and together they changed what could be said.

The first edition of this book was finished on 23 October 2026 and corrected on 24 October 2026. The correction is described in the front matter and is not hidden. That is the standard this book holds itself to, and the reader is entitled to hold it to it.

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The record is not closed. §11 lists what remains open, and any reader who wants to close it further has the map. If you find the passenger list, write to me.

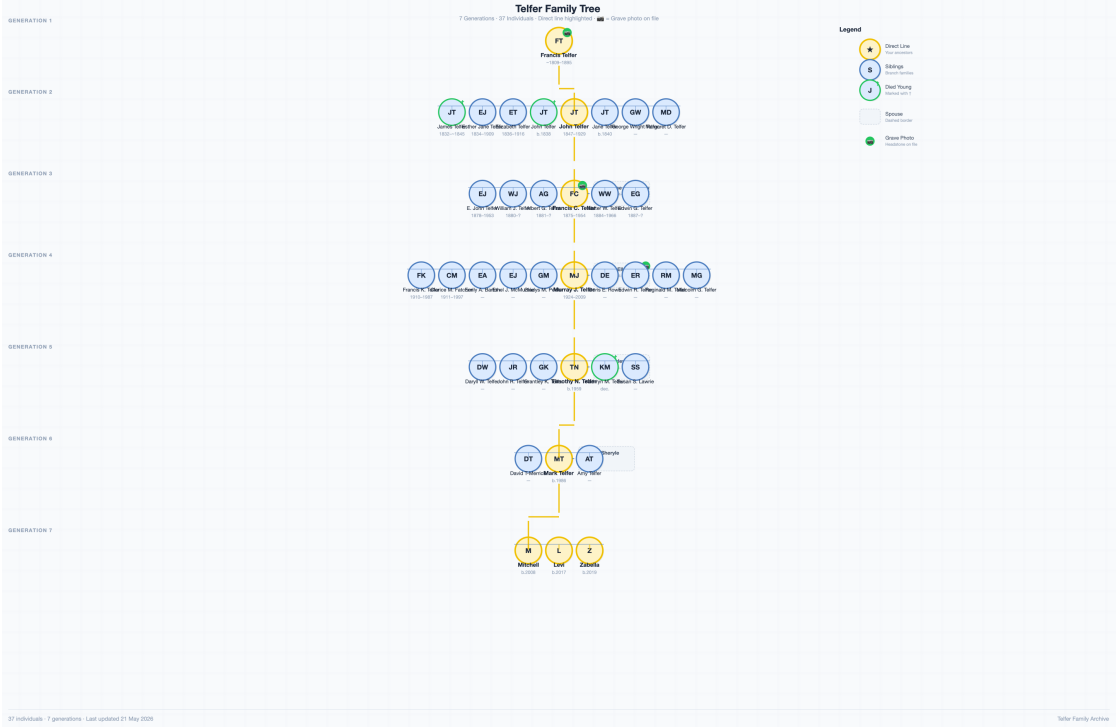
*— M.T., Kippa-Ring, Queensland, 24 October 2026*

# FOLD-OUT
# THE FAMILY TREE

*The Queensland direct line: 37 individuals, seven generations, from Francis Telfer (c.1809–1895) to Mitchell, Levi and Zabella. The yellow line is the direct line.*

*None of the Lanarkshire or Ōtorohanga people in this book appear on it. That is the point of the book, drawn.*

Telfer Family Archive, 21 May 2026.



# The Plates

Four documents and images carry this book. Three are reproduced in place, against the argument they support, so the reader does not have to hold a finger in two pages at once. One is a map rather than a document: the family tree, printed as a fold-out at the back.

- Plate 1 — the baptism entry for Alexander Telfer, 1841. §4.
- Plate 2 — the Prince George, the barque that carried the Roxburghshire line out in 1838. §8.
- Plate 3 — Blackburnfoot, Liddesdale, where Francis Telfer was born. §1.
- Plate 4 — Eskdalemuir Chapel, where Francis's sons were baptised. §8.
- Fold-out — the direct line, seven generations, 37 individuals.

**What is not here, and why:**

There is no photograph of Alexander Telfer of Lamington, because none is known to exist. There is no photograph of the Ōtorohanga Telfers in this book, because this book is about documents and the living family has not been asked for one. There is no image of the Dimboola man, because the only thing that identifies him is an index line — and an index line is reproduced as a quotation, not a picture.

A book that illustrates itself with whatever happens to be in the folder teaches the reader to trust decoration. This one shows only what the argument rests on.